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## Epilogue

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### Section Title(S)

Chapter Seventeen: Contemporary Egyptian Nubians

Working as servants, surrounded by non-Nubians, Nubians spoke their own language, a practice which, like the employment itself, was both stigmatizing and at the same time offered a degree of independence. Thus Nubians could discuss their work, criticize their employers and share "inside" jokes, which provided them with a sense of superiority over others, even while their language marked them as *barabra*. Whatever the negative opinions of other Egyptians, the Nubians' ability to control, to a degree, the conditions of their employment made their work more acceptable. Furthermore, many Nubians had jobs requiring high levels of trust and responsibility and intimate contact with people of high status.<sup>10</sup> It seemed to us who lived among Nubians in the 1960s that it was with the elites of Egypt, native and foreign, that many of the Nubian men identified; the elites were the people whose manners they admired and to whose standard of living they aspired.

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Considering the above, it is tempting to conclude that before the High Dam, the mystifications of the "Blessed land" (as the Nubians called Nubia), that impoverished shore of the Nile where they felt themselves free in their own beautiful universe, were reinforced by the Nubian experience in urban employment. In the cities, the Nubians, like many white collar office employees, identified with their employers, not with the workers outside.

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However, the sense of personal worth which seems to have resulted has served the Nubians well, helping them through the radical adjustments of the last twenty years.

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What has happened in the last twenty years? Have the Nubians of Egypt been able to maintain their illusions of independence? Can they now reproduce their old symbolic world in a new setting? What has become of their sense of personal identity and their social goals? The answer is complex and to generalize about all Egyptian Nubians today is even more questionable than to generalize about them historically. However, there are some strong tendencies which we can describe, which seem to be part of the direction in which many Nubians are moving. To do so, we must look briefly at the long term effects of the conditions of resettlement as well as their social and economic adjustments within the context of greater Egypt and the Middle East today.

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The old Nubian villages were scattered along the banks of the Nile from Aswan to the Sudan border, a distance of 350 kilometers; the new settlements were constructed on a crescent of land about 25 kilometers long. While the districts were lined up as they had been in Nubia, individual villages in the districts have disappeared into the general housing projects. The houses are constructed terrace-fashion, straight rows, wall-to-wall. Houses with the same number of rooms were  191 placed on the same row and assigned according to family size. Thus the new houses have lost their relationship with the organic nature of the community; kinsmen have been scattered far and wide, and old patterns of neighborly reciprocity have been broken.

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10 Perhaps it is worth thinking about the Mamluks, the Muslim slaves who became rulers in Egypt, however anomalous their rise to power may seem to western observers.

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